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Danny D'Imperio

Drummer Danny D'Imperio has thrived in a variety of musical settings including classic jazz with the Salt City Six, big band with Woody Herman and Maynard Ferguson, and hard bop with his own group, The Bloviators. His recordings as a leader include "Glass Enclosure," "Hip To It" and "Still Comin' On Up" with The Metropolitan Bopera House.

Danny was interviewed in Cortland, New York, on June 30, 2014, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm here for the Fillius Jazz Archive, in Cortland, New York with drummer and band leader Danny D'Imperio. Thanks for joining me.

DD: My pleasure.

MR: You and I are only a few years apart, and I have some vivid memories of what grabbed me as a kid musically, and I'm wondering what grabbed you?

DD: Well first of all my father, who was that man there, was a musician. And I was born on March 14, 1945 in Sydney, New York, and we lived in Unadilla, New York. And he quit playing. At that time he was four years old, that was on the centerfold of the *New York Times* along with Crown Prince Hirohito, who was 16 years old. I've got the original newspaper upstairs. It's just barely holding together. But he quit playing drums when he was about five. I mean you can see by those drums, I mean with that gooseneck hanging down. Actually it's hard to see but there actually is a cymbal that's attached to the bass drum pedal. They didn't have high-hat cymbals in those days and so like when you hit the drum the cymbal would also hit the drum with the bass drum beater. I'd love to have that set of drums but I don't know whatever happened to it. But anyway, he quit playing drums shortly thereafter. And around the age of 12 or 13 he contracted rheumatic fever and stayed home from school for one year as a result, and learned how to play the piano. So when I was born he worked for the War Department, he couldn't get in the service at that time because of the rheumatic heart, so he worked for the War Department, and played piano on the side. So my first recollections when we lived in Unadilla, New York on the coffee table in the living room were the old 78 albums, which you open them up and there'd be four or five 78's in it, and there'd be Fats Waller and Art Tatum, and people like that, Artie Shaw, you know, all of the famous guys at the time. And I got kind of attracted to that. I said, like they'd put them on the record player and I'd rock, like I'm rocking now, I rocked so much in my crib upstairs in my bedroom that I actually (and I've got the scar to this day) rocked my crib into the hallway and the whole crib came right down the stairs and my mother and father thought I was dead. But one of the scars is

there, I'll tell you about the other one which I got later on. But I was always rocking. I just always loved to rock. Even in a car, even in a straight chair I rock. I don't know why but I do. But the music was always in the house. And my uncle was a bass player, my grandfather — who lived to be 100 — was a violin player and a shoemaker, and his wife, my grandmother, my father's mother, was a pianist — not a jazz pianist but a pianist, and they played the theater circuit with this fascination of a 4-year-old drummer, and they ended up playing the Hippodrome Theater in New York City with Baby Rose Marie, who was later on I believe "The Dick Van Dyke Show," Rose Marie. And she was on the bill as well in the Hippodrome Theater. So that was the way that started. But my fascination came from the musical part of my family.

MR: Was the — are you Italian?

DD: I'm 3/4 Italian, 1/4 Irish. My grandmother, the pianist, was born in Ireland. That's a nice combination.

MR: No kidding.

DD: And the other three are Italians.

MR: I just wondered, you know, the Italians often have a musical heritage, with the mandolins and all that.

DD: Well he was a violinist, and baritone horn player too. My grandfather.

MR: Do you recall if the music that you were getting into, were your parents using the word "jazz" or was it just the music that was in the house?

DD: Well I mean first of all I was 4 years old when it started so I don't know if it was swing or big band. I can't really recall the word "jazz" until later on. We moved to Buffalo in 1949, and that's when the jazz started to come into play. But I mean as I would call it, it was like the big band era, the swing era you know, like Benny Goodman and all of that. The jukeboxes would be loaded with that kind of music. "Stardust," and "I Can't Get Started With You," and "Begin the Beguine" with Artie Shaw, and all of that stuff.

MR: So by the time you were in like junior high school, had you decided on your career path so to speak?

DD: Well we can start a little bit earlier than that. When we moved to Buffalo my father decided I was going to be a piano player. And I took piano lessons. And we lived in downtown Buffalo for a couple of years, and I started learning out of the Thompson method. And then in 1952 we moved to Cheektowaga, New York, which is a suburb of Buffalo, and every time we moved I'd have to change piano teachers, and that piano teacher would start me over with their method. So like I was becoming very disenchanted. You know like okay I got to this point, but no, I want to start you the way I teach so then we'd start over. Then we moved here, to Cortland, in 1953, and I started again on the piano. By this time I was becoming very disenchanted, although I wish I had

stuck with it because it sure was a lot easier to play an acoustic piano than it was to lug that stuff around. So anyway, that thing kind of fizzled out. Then I took up the trumpet. That lasted for a couple of years, right up here at Parker School, a couple of blocks away. And that was okay but that didn't work out either. And in 1956 Tommy and Jimmy Dorsey, the Dorsey Brothers Orchestra, came to Cortland. You went by it on your way here, it's a place called Skateland. It was a roller skating rink. Now it's just a vacant building. It became Grossman's Lumber and it's just a building up there. Well we went in that summer, and I still hadn't focused on — my father just said, "he hasn't got it, he just doesn't have it man, you know I mean he's not going to be a musician." Because I had dropped two instruments.

MR: But he wanted you to be.

DD: Well he wanted me to be exposed to music. I'm not sure he wanted it to go quite the way it went, as you will find out later in the interview. But I walked into that thing, it was July of 1956. And at that time Jackie Gleason was big, but he would have a summer replacement and it was Tommy and Jimmy Dorsey. In fact, that summer replacement — one of the episodes of the summer replacement was when the juggler was on the show of the Dorsey Brothers, when Charlie Parker was watching it, as he died. In fact in the movie you see the juggler and in the scene when he's in the Stanhope Hotel with the Baroness de Koenigswarter, they used the actual scene. Well that summer they also went on the road. So anyway I walked in there, and the drummer was Louis Bellson. He was married to Pearl Bailey. And she was in an automobile sitting behind the place, she didn't come in. But he drove separately from the band. And he did a drum solo — now I'm not a hundred percent sure it was "Skin Deep," because that was what he did with Duke Ellington. But, since it was his arrangement and I'm sure he owned the rights to it, it very well could have been "Skin Deep." I just know that it was pretty deep. And I watched it. And Charlie Shavers was playing trumpet, Lee Castle was in the trumpet section, which is neither here nor there, Frank Maynes, and then they broke down to the — I think they call it the Clambake Seven when they went to a Dixieland band. But the band was ferocious man, absolutely ferocious. And Louie Bellson was ferocious. So I said to my father, I said, "why don't I try the drums?" So we went down to a local music store. And he wasn't going to buy me a set of drums, because he had seen me lose interest in the other things. So we bought a practice pad, a pair of drum sticks, and Duke Ellington's "Ellington Uptown," which featured Louis Bellson playing "Skin Deep." Well from then on it was pretty much drums for me.

MR: Louie Bellson was with the Dorsey Brothers after Ellington?

DD: Yes. That record, that "Ellington Uptown" I believe was in '52 or '3, and they came here in '56. It was July of '56. For Christmas that year — I had never touched the drums up

until this point. I had a practice pad and I wrecked pillows and, you know, I was ruining the furniture playing along with it. I think I had a cardboard drum or like one of those things kids get. They're not going to last long, especially if you're trying to play "Skin Deep," which I mean I never could play that anyway. But the thing is that that whole bit, like that Christmas I got a snare drum, a 26" bass drum and one steel cymbal. And it was steel, it was not brass or anything. I've never seen one like it before or since. I gave it to somebody else just as a thing. But he wasn't even going to give me a hi-hat stand yet. He said — see he played piano and he had an organo attachment, which is a thing you may or may not be familiar with, but you used to put things underneath the piano keys and this big amplifier on the side made it sound like an organ and you'd control the volume with the thing that came out and you'd move your legs. So he would play all the left hand, and he was a very strict timekeeper anyway.

MR: It was called a what?

DD: An organo — O-R-G-A-N-O. It's a great big amp, and you had to have them come and put all the things underneath the piano keys, and then you'd turn the thing on and then it had little things — so it made it like an organ sound and he played the bass and I'd be playing along with it. But he was so strict on me. And he was playing with Spiegle Willcox's band at the time. And Spiegle and the guys — in other words I got this thing and as the time went on, that spring, he would bring the guys in and I would improve. I mean they started coming in when I had the pad, just come in and have a drink before going to a job. And he would criticize me pretty bad. I mean it was kind of embarrassing actually. Because if I screwed up the time or overplayed a drum break, I mean he'd say, "you overplayed that break." Then they'd all get in the car and drive off to the job and leave me alone with my muse you know. And I would feel sad about it. You know, but it wasn't like he was being mean it was just a straight fact. But my first job came in July of 1957. A wedding reception. And I had — you're looking at a guy right now who is 69 years old, and you're looking also at a guy who's never worked a day in his life, ever. Now the Army was considered training. I mean I did Basic Training then went into Army bands. But I mean I don't consider that working, that's training. So I played my first job, I made nine dollars. I shared a paper route with another guy once, a half a paper route, so I did have a half a paper route. Wouldn't take a full one. Working was just not in my comfort zone once I made that nine dollars for three hours. I said that's it, rather than getting 50 cents to mow or rake a lawn.

MR: I know exactly what you're saying.

DD: I'm not sure that this is the best information for students who may be watching.

MR: I agree. I mean I made four dollars on my first gig. But I made 35 dollars on my first New Year's Eve gig when I was still in high school and I said, "oh my God." But I think it's interesting that your father said, "you overplayed that break."

DD: Like in other words, at the end of the tune — the LP was coming in at that time. Between 1949 — I think Columbia was the originator of the long playing record. They used to be on ten inches. But there was two records that I remember particularly on that table when we moved to Cortland here, was Harry James' "One Night Stand," and he had a drummer named Jackie Mills who absolutely floored me. But what was even more impressive, or as impressive, was a Ted Heath record called "Live at the London Palladium" and the drummer was Ronnie Verrell. And to this day when I play that record I get excited. I mean Ronnie Verrell, he was a devotee — his main inspiration was Don Lamond. And he played those Don Lamond breaks like — abstract breaks but man. That band was on fire. And I would be listening to that, and then the Salt City Five was a Dixieland band that had won the Arthur Godfrey Show, and that was one of the records on the table, and I wore the cushions on the couch out playing along to that with a drummer named Bob Cousins — and I later went with the Salt City Six, and finally got to meet Bob Cousins and actually played bass with him, because I play the bass as well — not as well, I mean in addition to the drums. And I actually got to play with one of my idols, was him. And then well we can continue on with the Don Lamond, Jake Hanna and that thing. But that's where that went. But then if you want to go — I'll let you ask the questions.

MR: Yeah. Were you developing, by the time you were in your teens and so forth, any kind of personal filter — oh I really want to play this kind of music and I don't care for this kind of music too much. Or was it just like a gig is a gig?

DD: No it wasn't quite like that. You see because of what I told you was on that table, there was the Salt City Five, which was Dixieland, then Eddie Condon's music called "Jam Session Coast to Coast," which had the Rampart Street Paraders on one side with Nick Fatool, a great drummer, and on the other side was the Condon band, which was just dynamite, with Wild Bill Davison and all those guys. And then there was a big band. So like I was in between — and like Ellington "Uptown" and I was right in between. So I had to learn — I learned all of these Dixieland songs, because Spiegle's band was coming out of that thing. Because he had played with Bix Beiderbecke in the Jean Goldkette Orchestra. So I pretty much came out of the direction of big band to small groups, to like we would play — another record that was on the table was the soundtrack from "The Benny Goodman Story." Now here I'm listening to Gene Krupa play "Sing Sing Sing" and I'm playing it on the floor and I'm keeping my father awake as he's taking a nap getting ready to go to a gig. He said, "you've got to stop, I'm taking a nap." But on one side of that was the Benny Goodman Trio playing "China Boy" and "Avalon" — the

quartet was with Hamp. So I started playing that music. So I mean it was all subsumed. It was subsumed as just being jazz.

MR: That's so interesting, because I had the same experience with the soundtrack from the Glenn Miller movie. A big band, and there were some Louis Armstrong cuts on the other side because he was in the movie.

DD: It's funny you would say that because Moe Purtill, the original drummer with the Glenn Miller band, who is on that, sat right here and played drums. He came with a friend of mine and my father played piano over there, I played the bass, and Moe was right there. What a thrill. I mean I met Moe and we became good friends. He was one of my heroes too because one Christmas I got that little deluxe edition 45s of the Glenn Miller edition with Moe Purtill and that was one of the records that I had when I got that set of drums. I didn't even know how to tune a set of drums, because it was calfskin heads in those days. I didn't know if you're supposed to loosen them up on hot summer days. One day I woke up in the morning and all my drum heads were split because the sun was beating down on them and they tightened up. I said, "who's been playing my drums." They went, "nobody, they've just been sitting in the sun."

MR: Okay. So do you remember what kind of music, some of the songs you would have played at your first wedding gig?

DD: Well I mean it would have been "It Had to be You," — oh what were the songs — "Poor Butterfly." Of the songs — the standards of 1956. I mean we weren't playing Patti Page's "Love" or whatever, "Love Love Love." We weren't doing that kind of stuff. We were doing "Someday Sweetheart," "Charmaine," "I Found a New Baby." Things like that. But usually at weddings you couldn't really unload because dancers, you know, they've got to do the — now I've got to play a waltz, for the wedding waltz or whatever it was, things like that. So I had to learn that. I had to learn how to play a cha-cha. You know, the bossa novas weren't in yet so at least I was spared that. I'm not a big cha-cha fan and I don't even like bossa novas to be honest with you. You can edit that out.

MR: That's okay. Hey you don't have to like everything. Well it seems like you must have been getting to a point where you decided well this is what I'm going to do.

DD: Well as I said, well okay, between my junior and senior year of high school of course I discovered the joys of physical relationships with women along that period of time. And my girlfriend at the time happened to be the prettiest girl in the school. But I had played, at the age of 15, now I had gotten mononucleosis and had to stay home for two weeks. Mono is a blood — they call it "kissing disease" actually. So anyway, as soon as I got released from that I'm going back to school and Arnie Koch from — they're reforming the Salt City Six up on Memory Lane up in Syracuse. Jack Maheu, Will Alger, trumpet player Paul Squire, my father on piano — because I had sat in with the Salt City Six prior

to that, when I was 14. But let me preface that by saying that because my eyes were bad at that time we used to go to New York. And we'd go to the Taft Hotel when Vincent Lopez's band was playing. Because my father — we would stay at the Taft and they used to have a thing called "Shake the Maracas" contest, which was a radio show. And they had me sit in on drums at 14. I've got photos of it. And man I was more nervous than a prostitute in church. Or you could say a whore in church. But you can edit that too. So anyway, I sat in. So every time we went there I sat in with them. Then he would take me down to Nick's to hear either Billy Maxted's band or whatever band was in Nick's. And then we'd end the evening — we'd go to Birdland of course, but we'll get to that a little later — and the Hickory House went to four in the morning so I'd go and hear Marian McPartland's trio.

MR: Joe Morello?

DD: No Joe was gone by then. But the drummer that I did see there was Jake Hanna. And that was my first meeting with Jake. But let's see, okay, so anyway, let's get back to when I was 15, during that summer break, I had played with the band, okay, in the fall, at age 15 I had been released from my medical restrictions because of the mononucleosis, to go back to school. The phone rings and now they want me to play at Memory Lane with the Salt City Six. And now this job went on, they used to go from nine to one or nine to two in those days. I of course never made school on Monday morning. And here I am now playing, and I wasn't even legally allowed to in those days, because you're not supposed to be playing in gin mills. That was a law. But I looked a little old for my age, like I do now. But one time my homeroom teacher came in and he says, "now I know why you're never at school on Monday mornings." He said, "that's all right I like jazz, I'll cover for you." But anyway, so that summer they called and they said, "we want you to go on the road with us permanently, we're going on the road." So that was a decision. My mother was, "oh no you can't, no you're not going on the road at age 16" or whatever it was. And I was begging. I says, "man, I'm not mowing lawns, I'm not doing anything, I'm not playing Friday nights." I didn't play with the school dance band because why play for 3 dollars at the YMCA when I could be making 15 — well it was 12 to 15 to 18 dollars with my father's band or Spiegle's band, or whatever band. Anyway my father said, he said, "okay we're going to let him go but we're going to put him in charge of Jack Maheu and Will Alger, that they'll watch out for him." That was like letting the hen guard — the fox guarding the henhouse. These guys, man I was loaded constantly with these guys. Now they're going to Pennsylvania to play at the Penn Sheraton and the legal drinking age is 21 there. Now 18 here. See that means it's all changed in New York State as you know. So we'd go to after-hours clubs and we'd be playing liar's poker and I'd be getting — and then of course I came home in the fall and had to go back to school for my senior

year. That was between my junior and senior year. And I played with the high school band all of that time. I had actually, to back it up a little bit, from Parker School up the street, for disciplinary reasons, I was sent to St. Mary's School which is right about seven houses that way. They didn't have a band. So they figured — so here I am not really learning how to read music as well as I'd like to have, and Burton Stanley was a professor up at Potsdam, was the band director there. And he played a job with a big band up in Syracuse with Spiegle, up at Hotel Syracuse. I sat in and he said to my father, "you've got to let me have him. You've got to send him to the high school." Well I was asked, delicately asked, to leave St. Mary's School for disciplinary reasons once again. Not like kids today carrying guns to school, but just a troublemaker you know, or whatever, talking back, that kind of thing. So I get to the high school and I went right to Burton Stanley and the high school band director and I said, "Prof," we called him Prof Stanley. Corky Fabrizio took his place because he went up to Potsdam. And I said, "Prof, you'd better put me in the junior band." I said, "my eyes, I'm not going to be able to read this music in senior band." He said, "let me worry about that." He said, "your eyes will catch up to your hands, don't worry."

MR: Do you mean your eyesight?

DD: No. My reading. Yeah. "Your eyes will catch up to your hands."

MR: Okay. I didn't quite understand, if your eyesight was bad.

DD: No I mean it's like "nice eyes baby" you know, in other words like you can read real well. And it didn't take too long. I was always hoping for a sunny day during marching band season because then we'd go outside and be practicing marching band stuff, which was no problem. But on rainy days we had to go into symphonic or concert band and oh man, that was, for me, I just didn't enjoy that.

MR: Did your fellow, if you had friends that were musicians, were they jealous or were they enthralled by your quote road gigs and stuff? Or were they aware that you were doing that?

DD: Well are you talking during the high school years?

MR: I'm talking of high school, yeah.

DD: I was just gone. I mean I think a couple of them thought that my girlfriend might be available which wasn't the case. But I guess so. I guess they could have been jealous. But they — see I was into the jazz thing. And they were into Buddy Holly and that kind of a thing. I mean Ronnie Dio was from Cortland. I mean Ronnie Padavona, but he went with Ronnie Dio. I don't know if you remember him with Black Sabbath? He passed away a couple of years ago. And there were several famous musicians from Cortland. I mean Ray Crisara played with Toscanini. And there was Arnold Gabriel had the Air Force Band for like 30 years. He was the conductor of that.

MR: What's his name?

DD: Arnold Gabriel. It was funny, like Toscanini's son, his father was Frank Crisara. And they had the Old Timer's Band here in Cortland. And all those musicians, they still have it but it's not the Old Timers, I mean they're all gone. They were old timers when I was — 50 years ago they were old timers. They still call it the Old Timers Band. I guess guys like me are in it, but I don't play in it. So he comes home from playing with Toscanini and they're having a rehearsal. And Frank Crisara, a handlebar moustache guy like this, and although the trumpet player's naturally going to give the lead trumpet part to his son, Ray Crisara, who I think is still alive teaching school in Austin, Texas. Fantastic trumpet player. Fantastic. And he had the Italian accent, because I used to live — so he starts playing whatever it is, and he looks back and he sees that his son is playing the solo cornet — or solo trumpet, first trumpet — solo cornet it was. He said, "what the hell is goin' on around here?" He says, "dees guys they come here every week over hea." He says, "maybe you play first chair with Toscanin, you play last chair with me." And here Bob Britano and all these guys said fine. But he was one of the famous guys from Cortland. There's been a few of them from here.

MR: You know you mentioned Buddy Holly, and that era of rock & roll. When I listen to that music, in fact I play a lot of it now, a lot of it's basically swing music.

DD: Actually it is.

MR: Right? "Rock Around the Clock" is a swing song.

DD: Um hum. It doesn't have an eight beat feel.

MR: Right that music didn't —

DD: I didn't want to be — I mean rhythm & blues was nice, you know, Louis Jordan and the Tympani Five. That was something that was sitting on the dining room table. I can't remember all the names of the tunes, I've still got them there. But I mean that was Earl Bostic, all of those were swing music. But when it went into eight beat, when it started becoming [scats] that's when I kind of lost interest in it.

MR: Can I ask you about — I don't think I've heard that term in a long time, "eight beat."

DD: Well eight beat meaning straight eighths as opposed to like a shuffle or a ding-ding-ka-ding, where the right hand's playing eighth notes.

MR: Okay, even up and down eighth notes.

DD: Right. And I like to play that kind of music because that freed me up, which a lot of guys didn't. See a lot of guys, a lot of the swing players played four on the floor. Even though Blakey feathers the bass drum and all of those guys, and so do I. But it's not like a pounding four on the floor. We call it four on the floor. But I like to — once I started hearing some guys dropping bombs, that's when I said now that frees me up to like not be necessarily — because once the bass amps came in, the timekeeper in the band is the bass

player, really. You know. He's the one that's laying the time down. And I'm there to shade and color. Somebody'll say, "well it's dragging" or "it's rushing." I mean yeah, you can put an edge on the beat or put it behind the beat or whatever. I mean I've got a Miles' Davis record, "Miles at the Black Hawk" when they start "Bye Bye Blackbird" at a certain tempo, and it's almost a ballad by the time it ends. But it's swinging all the way down.

MR: Swinging all the way down. Yow.

DD: Yeah but to just sit there like [scats]. You know I like to [scats] you know, like break it up a little bit.

MR: I think that's very interesting what you just said about the bass player.

DD: Yeah, they're the timekeeper.

MR: I agree.

DD: Especially when amps came in. Now when they were just back there and they couldn't be heard, you know, they had to have the strings a lot higher off the fingerboard because they had to pull harder. But now they've got the amp, let the amp do the work, I can put the thing down and the facility's more there, and it changed.

MR: So what happens if the bass player starts being looser with the time, and you are too, and the drummer is too.

DD: Well when you say looser with the time, are you thinking of Bill Evans with Scott LaFaro?

MR: I guess, or, I guess just bass players who want to be more involved —

DD: In interplay with the — okay.

MR: Yeah.

DD: Okay well that was when Scott LaFaro came into the game, and Bill Evans, and that's when things started to change. But at that point the music was changing and, but it didn't mean that you didn't have to have that metronome in your head. You still had to know where it was. But everybody had to know then. It wasn't somebody sitting there with a metronome keeping track of it. You know, I mean it was in your head at that point.

MR: What was the first bop record that you heard, or did you hear bop live first. How did it sort of enter?

DD: The first bop record I ever heard was with my father when we went over to Oneonta, New York. In those days they used to have speakers outside of the music store playing the latest things, you know, that kind of thing. And we went in there, and I've still got the original 78. It was "One Bass Hit" by Dizzy Gillespie. And on one side was the big band version and on the other side was the small band version. And I've still got that 78. And I said, now that got my attention. That did get my attention. And that was the first one. But that would have been in the early 50's as well and I hadn't even started drums yet.

MR: Did you start leaning towards that kind of music, to play bop or hard hop?

DD: Well, as I said earlier, we used to go to New York to go to a certain optician — let me see is it optician or —

MR: Is it an optometrist?

DD: No it's the guy that is a doctor. It's an optician, isn't it? Not an optometrist. Not the guy that makes the glasses, no, this is an optician. And as I'd say we'd go, and I was starting to get into listening to the bebop pretty good then. Although we would always go to Nick's, we'd always go to Condon's, we went to the Metropole one day and we sat there for eight hours listening to Coleman Hawkins and Charlie Shavers and Mickey Sheen was a great drummer then too. He's since passed away. And I was in awe. And then they had two bands. The other band was Cozy Cole with Roy Eldridge and certain guys like that, which was amazing too. And I mean I was just staring at this. I said, "man, this is something else."

MR: I wanted to ask you a question, sort of rewind. You saw Charlie Shavers in the Dorsey band just down the street from here. Was there any — of course you were pretty young — but was there any significance to the fact that here's this black man playing, who probably was the only black person in the band, right?

DD: That's correct. Except for Pearl Bailey, who was not in the band.

MR: In the car. Do you remember that? Any significance to that?

DD: I remember that what they had done was — the hit song that he had at that time — no I mean Tommy Dorsey had a couple of hits. One was "Song of India" and the other was "Marie." But what they had done was they had transcribed Bunny Berigan's original chorus on "Marie" for the entire trumpet section. And man, when Charlie Shavers hit that night with that, I'm not sure that he had the lead part or not — I wouldn't be surprised but what he didn't — but when he did it just blew the place apart. Man, you know, like whether he took it up an octave I can't remember because that's so far in the past. But I knew that he — and then he — I'm not sure if he came down to play with the Clambake Seven or Lee Castle might have. No Charlie Shavers came down when they broke down — it was a band within the band. You know they used to have bands within the bands.

MR: But there was no —

DD: I didn't think much about it, black or white, especially when I got in the Army.

MR: And were you drafted?

DD: No. I went on the road. Well I'll explain that one okay. I graduate from high school. I was accepted — I wanted to get to Potsdam because Prof's family was up there. But once again the physical attraction I had to the female I was going with in high school probably cost me commendable grades. So I got a letter from Prof Stanley that said, he said, "you are head and shoulders above any of the drummers up here but we can't let you in

because your grades are not high enough." I got out of high school with band, orchestra, chorus and theory. I mean I just barely got out. I couldn't wait to get out anyway. Then I got accepted to Ithaca College, because I had studied with Warren Benson back when I was at St. Mary's, with no band director there. And I had paid my $200 initiation fee and I had a jam session with a bass player, now deceased, named Tony Leonardi, and Frank Pezzullo and a whole bunch of guys from the Syracuse area. And he was with Jimmy Cavallo's band. I don't know if you ever heard of him. He made a movie called "Rock Rock Rock" or, I don't know. Jimmy Cavallo and the House Rockers. We called it Jimmy Cavallo and the House Wreckers. But the phone call came in, "come out here to New Bedford and join the band." This was like I graduated on a Thursday and I'm on the road on Sunday. And I did that for the entire summer and didn't go to Ithaca College. Tony said, "there's no real reason to go over there." And I didn't. So I lost the initiation fee, which $200 in 1963 was $200. I mean it's probably about a thousand dollars now, I don't know. So I went on the road for the summer with that.

MR: The House Rockers?

DD: Yeah. What was that called? "Rock Rock Rock" or something?

MR: I can't remember.

DD: It wasn't "Rock Around the Clock."

MR: No, but I know the band you're talking about. This was a very hyped up shuffle —

DD: Yeah there was a lot of different people — Connie Francis was in that movie. I mean that was a movie. I mean they made a movie. I wasn't — it was before I was with the band.

MR: What did being "on the road" constitute? Like one nighters in dance clubs?

DD: No, well like depending on which band I was with — I went on the road with Jimmy Cavallo and we were playing weeklong engagements. We were like a week at the Thunderbird Lounge and wherever, New Bedford, Massachusetts, the Piccadilly Lounge. I remember they used to have a tank of piranha that was the high point of the evening, because we'd play on top of the bar and the bartender would feed the piranha something. I don't know what he was feeding them, goldfish I guess. And that was fun. But that was a club that was booking with Sonny Stitt one week and then Jimmy Cavallo, like we're there, and this and that. And then we'd do Lancaster, we'd do Hazelton, Thunderbird Lounge, I can't remember the name of all the places. But the bread was so light, you know it was just no bread at all. I made $75 a week, but I mean still it was better than — I was getting my experience anyway. But I wasn't getting any reading experience you see. And even though I had played tympani and played Grade 6 drum solos, things like that during high school, I mean I went to all-state you know down at the Concord Hotel and all this and that. But that kind of reading was different than reading jazz music. Because when you read an eighth note [scats] but if you read an eighth note in jazz it's like [scats],

you know, like you're hearing the syncopation. I see an eighth note and it's like baDA, not bada. You know, so that kind of thing. So I wasn't really locked into that. Now I quit Jimmy Cavallo's band and went back with the Salt City Six for a couple of years I guess. And we were traveling doing Florida, and I don't remember the places, whatever they were. And those were nice jobs. But in 1965 Vietnam was heating up.

MR: I just was thinking about this, when I was sort of reading about you. And I saw the years you were in the service and I'm starting to wonder.

DD: Okay. Now we'll go in that direction. So now I'm down in Florida. And the pre-induction physical, I had to take it. So I took it in Florida. And my drinking chops have always been pretty up. In fact, do you mind if I prepare myself a little grape juice?

MR: No, not at all. You go right ahead.

DD: In fact if you'd like some more, there's ice right here.

MR: You know I've been thinking about those years a bit, because my Vietnam experience was more connected with the draft lottery. And I basically escaped because I got a high number.

DD: Oh you didn't go in the service?

MR: I didn't have to go, or, I didn't.

DD: Well the night that I — I took my pre-induction physical in Jacksonville, Florida. We were playing at the Cape Colony Inn which was owned, it was in Coco Beach, Florida, which was owned by the astronauts. And a trumpet player, Paul Squire drove me up there. My father said, "I've never wished you any bad luck in your life," he says, "but now I hope you fail this one." And man, I stayed up all night. We did every single thing we could put our hands on, including any controlled substance I could put my hands on, anything, to fail this exam. We drove up to Jacksonville, Florida wherever the physical was to take place, and I walked in and I mean I hadn't slept, I hadn't done anything except drink and get high and everything else. Here's these muscle men, I mean these are Charles Atlas, Man Mountain, Montana guys. They say, "hey," standing in line, I'd hear like, "Herman Slabonski." "Yo!" You know, like, I'm right here. "Come on forward, we'll check you out," you know, this and that. So I mean all of these guys, and half of these guys are failing. I mean these guys are not — I don't know if they've got a heart murmur, I don't know what it is. And I'm standing there like, looked like Wally Cox you know, Mr. Peepers. Man, you don't remember Wally Cox.

MR: I do too.

DD: By the way, he happened to have been a war hero believe it or not. I mean you wouldn't think so, you know, Mr. Peepers. So now I said, "how was that." He said, "next." You know like, he kept going down the line, man, instead of go to the back of the line like Herman Slabonski had to go to the back of the line and start over. So now I get down to

the final table with the guys with the stamp. And I said I had to have failed, you know. He takes this stamp, I thought he was going to break the table. Bang! Fully qualified for military service. I said, "oh my God." Here we go man. I mean even my eyes. I mean I used to wear glasses. I had 20/200 vision, a couple surgeries and cataract surgery, I'm 20/20 now you know, except I have to use reading glasses. So anyway, we get back up to Cortland, now my father owned a bar around the corner called the Crystal Hotel. And it was right across the street from the draft board. And I went across to the lady, Helen Wood, the lady at the draft board. I says, "when is this coming?" She says, "it's coming down man, in a big hurry. You're going in within a month, or within 60 days, you're going to be in a military service." Now I didn't particularly want to go in the Marines. I mean that was not my first choice. But all of the recruiting guys kept juicing at my father's bar. So they said, "well you're a musician, why don't you try out for the band?" I said, "oh I'm not good enough to be in the Army band." I mean you know 'cause you've got to — I just didn't feel as though I was good enough. He says, "well why don't you take the test anyway?" I said, "okay, all right." So I went up to the Chimes Building in Syracuse, New York where they did the test. And they put this piece of music on and you have a tape recorder in front of you and you'd play it. You'd have to read the music, sight read it, and do this and that. And you have to play certain rudiments. Now the one thing I learned from my band director, my second band director, Alfred "Corky" Fabrizio, who still is alive and was in drum and bugle corps, was there was a set of rudiments called the "Swiss Army rudiments." Now they were not popular. In fact, I don't even know that anybody really even knew them yet in 1965. But he had showed me this one rudiment. I'll show it to you if you don't mind. So I get on this tape recorder. It's just a flam accent, but it's supposed to alternate, like [drums]. Now alternating, you can only go so fast, because you alternate [drums]. But the way to really, the Swiss Army do it, is you don't alternate it, you just do it one way [drums]. So now I went in and took this test. So like I'm playing it like I'm doing the alternating thing. And then instead of staying with the alternating as fast as I can go, I mean as fast as is possible to go, I started with the [drums]. Then I quit alternating. I went [drums]. They hadn't heard Swiss Army rudiments yet. They thought I was playing the flam accent. So when the thing came back, it said — I mean I read all of this stuff and it said score 97, which means superior rating. I means I didn't have to go to the Army school of music, which was in Rockville, Maryland I think or someplace down there, which at the time I was disappointed. I said I'm going to get a free college education — go two months, get the basic training, actually it's nine weeks because you're a week getting your stuff at Fort Dix. But I had to enlist to get this. You are pre-inducted to come right directly to the New York Army band, which was the country club of the Army man. I mean that's right across from the

Statue of Liberty, right where that thing I showed you there. So I had to enlist for three years in the Army, but that — and you're guaranteed 14 months. Of course then there's another 14 to go, that you can get a levy. You don't get washed out, you are picked for a levy from Washington and it's okay, somebody's needed. So I went to basic training and as soon as I got down to Governor's Island, Fort Jay, Governor's Island, right across from the Statue of Liberty, the percussion leader, Sgt. Wadkowicz, he dragged me right into that room. He said, "I want to hear that flam accent man." I said, "well you know I just got out of basic training man, and my chops are a little down." And I was — I mean when I say it my cover was blown because I couldn't play it alternating at that speed you know, but they didn't know the Swiss Army rudiments yet. But anyway, I now was into the New York Army band. Now the New York Army band had guys — everybody that didn't want to go wanted to be in that band because first of all you're right in New York City, and second of all you're not going to Vietnam. And that was the cream of the gigs. But none of the guys in the band were any good at big band stuff, at playing in big bands.

MR: This was a concert band.

DD: No — yes, this was a concert band. We played parades up and down Fifth Avenue, you know, the whole bit. But then there'd be the symphonic band, I mean the concert band, and I was good a tympani because that's what I played in high school, because of my ear, and I could tune and play the tympani and all that. So I wound up playing — so in other words all the guys in the percussion are saying they're supposed to alternate playing with what they call the stage band then, you know, the New York Army Stage Band, which are now called the Jazz Ensemble or whatever. And nobody could, none of those guys could swing. I mean they just couldn't do it. So as soon as I hit — but I couldn't read very well. I mean I could read music but I couldn't read swing music the way I should have been, I could read concert band music, but I didn't quite have it. But getting back to one of your former interviewees I guess was Sonny Igoe. Now I had met Sonny down at Nick's. In fact I've even got photos of Sonny giving me — sending drum sticks home and a photo of him and my father and then a photo of me with him. I actually look like him because I wore horn-rimmed glasses, and we look the same. I've got it upstairs someplace. So he sent me drumsticks home. But he was teaching upstairs over Henry Adler's studio. Now the band director that came in to the New York Army Band replaced a marching band director and the new director was named Mr. Shettle S-H-E-T-T-L-E. And he had come from the Seventh Army Symphony, which was the only symphony in the Army and I mean these guys were just so ragged. I mean he wanted a symphony orchestra. He did not want a marching band. But he was now transferred to the New York Army Band. And he'd be holding the tubas down and, you know, like shhhh, you know, "you're playing too loud." I mean it was a tremendous marching band, but he wanted

music not balls to the walls bluster. So he decided to get everybody a thing where the government paid for lessons. Well you could pick your own teacher. And I went up to Henry and I sought Sonny downstairs, and I said, "man, I'd really like to study with you." And I said, "I've been on the road with the Salt City Six" and this and that, "and I'm in the New York Army Band." And he wasn't being facetious I don't think, but he knew me and — we're not friends yet, but when I said I'd been on the road with the Salt City Six and he had been with Billy Maxted's band and he did a thing called the "Big Crash from China" which is beautiful. He said, "well maybe you don't need me." I said, "no man, don't get me wrong man, I need you, I really do need you." So he took me on and the government paid him his checks, eight weeks at a time, three dollars a lesson. And after the first lesson he put the thing down and he said, "I can see you're a swinger." But he got me onto this Bellson/Breines B-R-E-I-N-E-S. Bellson/Breines book. It was a breakthrough. I mean he would sit with me at the pad, the drums would be over there, and we'd play it and he said, "now this is the way that these are supposed to" — and we'd hum it and play it together. So all of a sudden that was what I needed to be able to read big band music. I can't read eighth notes like I'm going to read them in a concert band. I've got to read them in swing figures. And it wasn't — you didn't have Thad Jones-Mel Lewis charts in those days, or you know like even Basie charts you know And then we'd do the first half hour that way, then the second half hour we'd go to the set, he'd put the headphones on and have me start reading like Broadway stuff. Because he was the drummer with "The Gary Moore Show," and had been on several shows. He was a staff musician. I've got to tell you — I talked to him a month or two before he died. I used to call him on a regular basis. I really liked Sonny. But that was the breakthrough with all of that. Then he did come over to Eddie Condon's one time when I was playing with my own band The Metropolitan Bopera House — we'll get to that. And it was what I needed, I really needed. I'd take off in the morning and get on the Staten Island Ferry, because now we were over — well Governor's Island was transferred to the Coast Guard and we were transferred over to Staten Island. And I played the final ceremony. So that's why when I go down to Governor's Island I'm one of the last people from the Army, because I was 20, I go there, I was there a couple of weeks ago, I look in that band room and all I see is ghosts because those guys are like, a lot of those lifers were 40 years old and it kind of hurts. And then they opened it up for me last year, the old barracks, and I said, "can we go up in the attic," I said, "there's a lot of things that were a little un-military-like that took place up there. And I looked on the floor and there weren't any seeds.

MR: Nothing was growing.

DD: But I played the final ceremony there, and then I took that picture, and now in the bookshop and when you get off you see the whole history of Governor's Island, but I'm

one of the last guys from the Army that was there. But then we were transferred over the Staten Island and we were the first Army band, which is in that picture with me in front of the barracks. And then once the first Army was transferred down to Fort Monroe, Virginia, the second Army because the first Army and we became the New York Army Band. So that was the New York Army Band. But I would get the Staten Island Ferry and go see Sonny. But he would schedule the lessons so it would be the last lesson of the day, you know, so I would go in the afternoon and then he and I would together go over to Jim and Andy's, which was a popular jazz hangout for every band, and he would introduce me to Jake Hanna, Joe Jones.

MR: Oh Jake Hanna, yeah.

DD: He was doing the "Merv Griffin Show" I think. Yeah, that was a classic hangout where if you were looking for a musician just call downstairs, "we need a trumpet player" up in such-and-such a studio. But that was, so anyway, Sonny and I became really good friends. And he still owes me, even to this day, he owes me one lesson, because I got transferred to Korea. Now here's what happened with that. I mean was there something that you wanted to know a little bit more about the Army?

MR: No, that's cool.

DD: I showed you how I got in and all this and that. So now we're over on Staten Island with the New York Army Band and a levy comes down from Washington. Man, I was the drummer with the stage band. And everybody figured well D'Imperio's never going to get transferred out of here because there's nobody to replace him. And our First Sergeant's name was Joe College, or Howard Joe College, we called him J.C. And he said these — J.C.'s man they're just not going to be able to take him away, you know. Well the Army doesn't quite work that way. And he called me up in latrine, and he said, "Danny, a levy's come down from Washington and you're being transferred someplace in the Orient. We don't know where yet, but we're going to call Sergeant Shipp," who had already been transferred over there — S-H-I-P-P, "and try to get you in the Saigon band." I said, oh gee, this is wonderful. Okay, now I'm heading from like New York City right to Saigon, or worse you know. Because there were several division bands. See there was headquarter bands and there were division bands. Well anyway, the way it turned out was my orders were for Korea. So I mean that was a blessing unto itself you know. I mean it's not going to be Vietnam, it's going to be Korea. So now I get to what I thought was going to be the Eighth Army Headquarters Band in Seoul. So I get off my duffle bag and go in there, I'm coming in and, "oh you're from the New York Army Band and I see your rating was 97" and all this and that, I guess it was a recommendation. But the Seventh Infantry Division Band needs a drummer. And I said oh here we go. So now I head up towards the DMZ and I'm in the Seventh Infantry Division Band. Now in that

band was Carter Jefferson, the tenor player who was with Woody Shaw for years, with the Jazz Messengers, you know, later on. But he didn't know anything about — he had been with Little Richard and Jackie Wilson, bands like that. He was a black saxophone player from Washington. And I brought a bunch of tapes of Charlie Parker and this and that, which then I bought an Ampex reel to reel and we used to just sit and listen to that stuff and that's sort of the way he developed into a fine jazz player. He's since gone to his reward. But we were up there and we ravaged that country pretty good. In fact I delivered two twin sons up there. One of them is a principal bassist now with the Washington Opera, and the other one is a physicist in Brookhaven Lab. But we ravaged the hell out of Korea.

MR: What does that mean?

DD: Well I mean it was a smorgasbord of females, and there was more drugs than we could absorb.

MR: And the Korean War was over.

DD: No, no, this was during the Vietnam era.

MR: So America's presence was like post-war.

DD: Well an occupation — well it wasn't an occupation of course because we were not occupying that country. It was the Republic of South Korea. In fact there's still about 20 or 30 thousand guys over there. There was 50 thousand then. But it was an absolute wild time I'll tell you that. And then I wound up delivering my own twin sons there, but I couldn't get them out because I didn't have enough time to get married and do the paperwork, and then I finally got transferred back to America. And when I got home I threw it on the floor and I said to my parents, I said, "well there's your grandchildren." A picture of them. I think my mother looked at it and said, "you're going back aren't you?" And I said, "yeah, I'm going to go get them." But I had to figure out how to get there. So it took two years, so I worked at Three Rivers Inn in Syracuse. And then we did the — I got that job and my reading had improved and I got that job playing like Frankie Laine, and I can't remember all the people who came in but the various acts. But I played a session on bass one night with some guys and there was no bass player so I just started playing bass. So I said, "well I'll play bass in the band, that's fine with me." So I got to play with Billy Eckstine and the drummer was Charlie Persip. Here I'm playing bass with Charlie Persip who is one of my favorite big band drummers from Dizzy Gillespie's big band. That's another record that I was kind of weaned on, "Dizzy at Newport." Here's I'm playing bass with Charlie Persip playing drums. Patti Page — I played the bass on that show. I wound up playing bass the second time on the Frankie Laine show. We called it the Frankly Lame show.

MR: Frankly Lame.

DD: Yeah, we had a bunch of things, I can't remember. But what happened was a girl singer came in named Dana Valery and that's spelled D-A-N-A. A lot of people called her Dana Valerie but it was [pronounced Donna Va lerie] and she was Sergio Franchi's sister. Her real name was Falstagali, they're from Johannesberg, South Africa. Sergio Franchi was at the time, he's since passed away, he was kind of like a Mario Lanza kind of singer. And she was looking for a conductor. She wanted somebody to travel with her. She was doing it on her own, she was kind of up-and-coming. But she didn't want a piano — she wanted a drummer, because every time she went someplace the drummers were not up to what she wanted. But here I am playing bass on her show. But somebody said, "no this guy's a great drummer." Well, somebody said, "he's a fine drummer." So I said, "well why don't you come down to my house and have some spaghetti, my mother will cook it for you," which impressed her. Anyway I went on the road with her for a year, 1969, I traveled with her. We went to California, Mr. Kelly's in Chicago, we did The Washington in Puerto Rico, whatever. But we did the Persian Room in New York City. And here I am, the drummer, conducting the band. So I had to learn how to — I had taken conducting classes, which is one-two-three-four-one, but I had to learn how to do it in just reverse and play with the right hand — let's see, I can't remember even how — one-two-three-four-one. So I had to get all these conducting things down like that. So I was their drummer-conductor for a year. And it was fairly interesting but I had also, prior to that, done a week or a few days with Buddy DeFranco's Glenn Miller Orchestra, but had to go back with Dana Valery. And the call came — Dana came up and spent Christmas, she and her husband of the time, came up to our house and stayed there, put a nice little gift under the tree for me, and as soon as she got back to New York I called and quit.

MR: Oh yeah?

DD: Because I had got a call to go — I'm moving this rocking chair — I got a call to go with the Glenn Miller band and they were going to Japan. Now here's my ticket back. I said, "okay, I'll go." And we were going to London as well. So I quit and joined the Buddy DeFranco Glenn Miller Orchestra. And we did a recording, "Live in London" at the Royal Festival Hall. Now this was — I had never been this sick in my life. I was playing two bass drums then and endorsing Ludwig drums. Buddy DeFranco was a pretty serious taskmaster with time. I mean because of the dancers, he didn't want anybody stumbling over their feet. So there was not a lot of looseness involved with that band and the Glenn Miller office didn't want to vary too far from the Glenn Miller sound. So it was a learning experience. And I had come out of the Army and I said here I am back in the Army. That kind of thing. I did that — we went to London and I had one steak over there. Everything was fish & chips. The bars were closed at the wrong time. It seemed as though I just couldn't, you know like they'd close at 2:00 and then we were traveling, and they'd re-

open at 5 and by the time the job ends they were closed. I couldn't get loaded, I couldn't do anything. But I'm staying at the London Strand ghosting — we called it ghosting, you ever heard of ghosting?

MR: Um hum. You could explain it though.

DD: Ghosting means that one guy checks into a hotel room and two guys live in it. You break the bed down, one sleeps on the bed spring, and you split the bill. Because the Glenn Miller band didn't pay for rooms. And I'm on the floor. I wake up on the day of this recording session, of this live concert, which was two concerts which means four sets. We've got to do the whole show twice. And "Bugle Call Rag" was one of the tunes and I mean that thing was fast. And I called Buddy DeFranco and I said — my ghost went downstairs and said, "Buddy, I don't think Danny can even stand up," which I basically couldn't. It was food poisoning. I got food poisoning. And I said, "you've got to call Ronnie Verrell or somebody. Somebody's going to have to come in and do this job. I can't even walk." And they sent a doctor, which was socialized medicine at the time. And he came up to the room and he said, "this is the strongest thing I have for nausea" and everything else. He gave me a shot. I couldn't even go over for the sound check. I couldn't do anything. I just got in a cab and went to Royal Festival Hall and played. Twice. I mean two shows. And I managed to get through it. And it came out on the record although my drum solo on the record that was released on Paramount Records here was cut to a minute and a half. Japan recently released it and it's an eight minute drum solo. How I did that I'll never know. Twice, that night. But that was the sickest I've ever been on a bandstand in my life, recording live for I don't know how many people the Royal Festival Hall holds, but on the cover of the record, I'm on the cover of the record with DeFranco.

MR: Jeez, something to be said for adrenalin I guess.

DD: I guess, yeah.

MR: Well I've got to jump ahead a little bit because we're well into our second hour here. But your got your family home from Korea?

DD: Yeah. I left the band in Japan and went to Korea and brought them back. And then Gap Mangione was in there someplace. I used to play with him. Oh yeah, I went with Jack Maheu and then I went with Gap Mangione's trio for a couple of years, and we were playing on top of a bar. We did so many, he did two jobs a day. Steve Davis was the bass player who had been on John Coltrane's "My Favorite Things."

MR: Right. Was that at the Top of the Plaza or something like that? In Rochester?

DD: No, that's where I played — the Top of the Plaza was across the street, that touring thing with Maynard Ferguson.

MR: Okay.

DD: So, but Linc Milliman had come to my high school because he had gone to Fredonia with Don Menza, who had gotten him on Maynard's band, and he came here because he was a school friend of the choral director. And I met him. And then I worked with him off and on with Jack Maheu's Salt City Six. And Randy did — now an English band becoming an American band again — half English, half American. Randy Jones was the drummer. And he was leaving. So the bass player, Rick Petrone, asked Linc if he knew any drummers. He said, "yeah, call Danny D'Imperio." So now I'm getting on the bandstand with Gap and the phone rings in the bar and they wanted me to come with the band. And I get up on the bandstand with Gap and I said, "Maynard Ferguson needs a drummer." He said, "tell him to call the union." In other words, he was PO'd because he didn't want me to drop out. But I had always wanted to play with Maynard's band. Even though the band was in transition, it wasn't the "Rocky" band yet. It was the "Chameleon" band you know. I did that with him. We were still playing quite a bit of jazz —

MR: "Three Little Foxes" —

DD: "Three More Foxes," "The Fox Hunt," this and that. So I went with that band for a year. And man, when I got out of that band, I mean it was totally different than DeFranco's band. This was a bunch of pirates. I mean these guys were half from England, and they didn't care. I mean the bus used to just throb when it would go down, like we actually rolled a joint I think the length of the bus one time. It went from the front to the back. I mean each guy in the aisle is doing it like this and that. But when I got out of that band man, it was an experience man. Because Maynard was so loose and crazy as hell you know. I mean he had lived with Timothy Leary and experimented with hallucinogenic drugs. And I'd been on the band about a month or so and we would play this place in Cleveland. I can't remember the name of the high school. But the band director, one of the guys, I'm not mentioning any names, but one of the trumpet players had hit on a high school girl. And we were doing a seminar in the afternoon. A clinic. They called them clinics with Maynard, seminars with Woody. And this band director comes up to Maynard and he said, "look one of your trumpet players was flirting and hitting on one of our high school students and I've locked him out of the auditorium, but that's okay, I've got a kid who can cut it." Well that didn't sit too well. Maynard went off on this poor guy. He just completely went off on him at the seminar. And then he said, "now we can shake hands and let our trumpet player back in." It was a job, I felt sorry for the kid, the high school kid who thought he was going to have to play the lead trumpet part and he couldn't have done it. I mean he could play the high notes but he couldn't have done that. So we play the concert that night and everything went okay. The band director seemed like an awfully nice guy. Very nice guy. In fact he came up and complimented me highly. I felt sorry for the guy. But we had to leave our band equipment in his band room for

some reason. I don't remember exactly why. But then in the morning we came to pick it up. Well the English guys, one was — a couple of managers and sound guys and this and that, we brought the bus by to pick up the equipment and somebody said where's so-and-so face (an expletive face) and the poor girl that was one of his students pointed into the band director's room. We got our stuff. But these guys had gone through — these English roadies and managers had gone through that high school and placed smoke bombs and different things. Time-set smoke bombs. And we left there and apparently about an hour later they all went off. By the time we got to the next place Willard Alexander's office, the phone was off the hook. You know Maynard laughed about it. He didn't care. But I mean they blew the — I said what a band I'm on here, man. This is not Buddy DeFranco and the Glenn Miller Orchestra. Because I mean the Glenn Miller Orchestra had it in the contract if anybody on that band get busted for pot the band folds that night.

MR: The band folds?

DD: The whole band, the Glenn Miller band is over. So nobody dared like even —

MR: Right. There was some peer pressure there. Yeah, wow, I've heard of some stories but I never heard that kind of story. Do you think you play differently if you're under the influence than if you're not?

DD: Influence of what? I play differently when I'm drinking than when I'm not drinking. But pot, I've lost interest. I mean I smoked so much pot it was unbelievable. But I'm not so interested in that anymore. That paranoia feeling has kind of left me. Marching powder — Peruvian marching powder, also known as cocaine — that makes you rush, so I try to stay off of that unless I really need a lift. But that's just the way all of that stuff went down.

MR: But does booze make you play —

DD: It makes me take more chances and it makes me play looser.

MR: Looser. Okay. And you find that, at least at that time, was it similar for your bandmates too?

DD: Oh yeah. One time we were playing with Maynard's band and, oh that was a drinking band I mean it was just everything. But we were going to play at a place called the Beeches, which you know up there.

MR: Oh in Rome.

DD: Rome. We were coming through this area, and I said I've never played the Beeches before. And the guys said, "oh you've played here before," they said, "you were just drunk and you don't remember it." I said, "I know I haven't played this place." I said, "well I'll bet you I haven't." And they said, "what do you want to bet?" I said, "I'll bet you 200 shots of liquor that I haven't played this club" or this place. They said, "you're on." So we walked into the place and I'm sitting down and we're going on in an hour and

I'm having dinner, kind of sitting alone for some reason, I don't know why, but having some chicken. And when the managers went into office and saw the books for the last time the band had played there, and it was before I had joined the band. So the waitress comes over, this poor waitress, she just looked at me and she's got 20 shots of liquor on a tray. She says, "I think these are for you." I said, "oh yeah. Just set them right down here." But a lot of people don't realize man, that drinking 20 shots of liquor, there's a way to — first of all when you drink whiskey you're also breathing it in [gasps] like that. So I said, "just bring me another order of bread," and I took the 20 shots and put it in a glass, you know, 20 shots of liquor it didn't do anything. And I went on the bandstand and after playing "Give it One" and whatever else those lunatic tunes were, by the second set I was totally sober anyway. But I did the 20 shots. And we had been drinking all day anyway, and continued through the night.

MR: Is that — I'm trying to think how to phrase this question — that booze and so forth, and controlled substances and jazz, why is that almost considered to be —

DD: Synonymous?

MR: Synonymous. Is it partly because you spent so much time on the bus and in hotel rooms and stuff and you have all this time on your hands? Or is it just like this —

DD: Somebody once said that the only time a musician should drink is while he works, or when he's working. But you've got so much time. You work four hours a day. I mean I hate to say work, play, because I've never worked a day in my life. But I mean you're basically playing but I mean when you're on the bus man, it's party time. Like if you're traveling and you've got an eight hour ride, what are you going to do? I mean sit there and — I mean some guys played cards, but most of us would be listening to music and getting drunk or getting high, and you burn it off on the bandstand. But it's an occupational hazard. There's no question about that.

MR: Because often times you're playing in places and you're in a gin joint.

DD: Gin mills. Oh yeah, I mean that's when you should drink is when you play. We used to have the booze — I went to Eddie Condon's club. I mean I played there for three years after that, I was the house drummer there. But I don't know how far you want to get into this. You probably want to get into the Woody Herman years.

MR: Sure. But you survived it.

DD: Well I'm still alive.

MR: I mean you look pretty good.

DD: Pretty good is not quite good. I'm going to be 70 on my next birthday and I ran up a hill yesterday. I run. And they can't find anything wrong with me.

MR: But a lot of guys didn't make it.

DD: Well I don't know why. I mean my grandfather lived to be 100. But see I quit smoking cigarettes, I mean so I don't have that. I mean somebody said once that "a cat wouldn't even eat your liver." Well every time I go over to the VA, which I'm going to go tomorrow morning, they can't find anything — they say, "there's nothing wrong with you." I've got the results from my bloodwork. It said, "you're Vitamin D deficient." I guess that's the new big thing. But now — because in the wintertime the sun — I sit out in the sun, I mean I can't even get a sunburn. I don't know if it's because of my pigmentation or whatever.

MR: Wow. Well how was Woody Herman different?

DD: All right. I came back, after Maynard's band, went back with Gap Mangione for another year. Then Woody Herman's band called and I went with that band. And that band was an exciting band. It was one of the bands I wanted to play with. I had played "La Fiesta" with Maynard Ferguson for two years, and now I'm back playing "La Fiesta" with Woody Herman for another two years, which is basically a slightly different version because it doesn't have all of the high, featuring Maynard and that. But like "Four Brothers," "Early Autumn," all of that stuff. All of those things. But the high point of being with that band was the Carnegie Hall concert we did, which was a 40th anniversary concert. I really enjoyed — I mean everybody was there, Stan, all of them, the whole thing, in 1976. They made a record on RCA of the 40th Anniversary Concert Live at Carnegie Hall. And I was loaded for that one too. But I enjoyed it. And Jake, the three drummers, with me, Jake Hanna and Don Lamond. I've got a picture of the three of us together. We shared the drum chairs on that.

MR: Jake, he was a pistol, huh?

DD: He was a character. He used to come into Eddie Condon's all the time, and I used to see him all the time. I mean not all the time, whenever he was in New York. Because I was the house drummer at Eddie Condon's for three years too, which was another Dixieland club. But then on Sundays I had the Metropolitan Bopera House, my own band. And I played bass, he played drums, and some other guys would play piano after hours. I even got to play with Roy Haynes playing drums, and I'm playing bass. I got to play with some pretty good drummers at Eddie Condon's because I played bass with that. I mean Jimmy Campbell who had been with Woody earlier on, Jackie Williams, Earl Palmer. Anybody who would come in would want to sit in and so I'd play bass and somebody else would play piano and we'd play until four in the morning. The club was open until four in the morning. Woody — all the musicians wound up hanging out there because the club was open until four. So it was like an after hours hang. We would stop playing at 1:30 or 2:00, and for two more hours the place would be open. And you never knew who

was going to be coming in. Sarah Vaughan, anybody. Joe Jones would be at the end of the bar playing on a newspaper with brushes.

MR: That guy loved to do that, didn't he?

DD: Yeah, right.

MR: What were the toughest economic years for you, as far as gigs?

DD: I don't remember. Well Eddie Condon's closed in 1985. Both of my sons graduated from high school in 1985 and went to college in 1985. And there was a little lull in there that was a little nerve wracking. But my one son, the bassist, got a full paid scholarship to the Boston Conservatory, so that helped. The other one went to Manhattan School of Music and then decided he wanted to become a physicist so that took care of that. And I was working various jobs in New York and then Anita O'Day came into the game. And then I was with her. That was a funny one. Well then — oh I went to Florida for a few years, I ran the band down there at Marco Island, Florida. And that was fun for a while. I brought Steve Marcus down. But then the Buddy Rich band came and I got the call. I played Carnegie Hall with that band. But I mean that was kind of ridiculous. I mean I did the Blue Note with them and some jobs with that band. But I never, to be honest with you, I mean the guy, Buddy Rich was a freak of nature. There's no question about that. But I never even listened to that band's music particularly because I said I'm never going to have to play with that band.

MR: I see.

DD: So I get to Eddie Condon's, my first week at Eddie Condon's, the phone rings at lunchtime. I'm at home, I'm staying at an apartment with a friend, and it's Richie Barnes from Willard Alexander's office, and he said, "Buddy Rich had a heart attack out in Ann Arbor, Michigan. We need a drummer on that bandstand tonight." I said, oh jeez. First of all Buddy didn't have — there were no drum parts for that band because, I don't know — it's rumored he couldn't read music. So here I am I said, "how are you going to get me" — he said, "we'll get you on an airplane." They took me from the airport to the stage to play with that band. You want to talk about like — I had to baste myself in my own sweat. And I did that a couple of times. And then when he died I played with the band for a short time after that. But I mean you can't really replace — those bands — it just doesn't work. I mean they're the stars. Maynard Ferguson's band, now I mean guys can play high notes but it's not Maynard Ferguson. I mean Buddy Rich — I mean the Woody Herman band can go on because he was just more or less like — you know Glenn Miller had so many hits, the Glenn Miller band's probably working more than any other big band.

MR: Isn't that something? Yeah, he had a less personalized sound.

DD: Who is that Glenn Miller?

MR: Glenn Miller.

DD: Well I wouldn't say that because he had that clarinet lead. But the thing is that he was smart and half of the tunes that he made popular were public domain. "Little Brown Jug," "American Patrol," I can't remember all of them but he didn't have to pay any royalties on those tunes you know, so I mean he made a fortune. I mean well of course there's some different opinions on that. Some people say that Glenn Miller should have lived and his music should have died. Other people say that he should have — the plane should have gone down with him and the music in it — you know, certain guys. But I mean I enjoyed playing with the band. I learned a lot, because Buddy DeFranco was so strict you know, like with the thing. So I did learn a lot from playing with that band. And that thing right there, that's a plaque of a platitude — we did a Glenn Miller "In the Mood" — that's a million is it? Seller. And we did three of them and it's gone triple platinum of the three of them. So that's what that — "In the Christmas Mood."

MR: Do you get payments, royalties, for any of the stuff you've done?

DD: Not for that. That thing I get royalties because they used some of that the music in, well Sandra Bullock's "While You Were Sleeping" and there was another one I think called "The Little" — how do you say it, "Fockers?" Or the little something.

MR: Oh yeah, "Meet the Fockers" or something, the second one.

DD: They used some of that, music for that, and I get some minor royalties from that.

MR: I see. Let's suppose —

DD: Let me give you some, let's move on into Anita O'Day.

MR: Yeah.

DD: Now this is a — I did a record with her out in California.

MR: Anita O'Day. Okay.

DD: For some reason she came in to the picture because it's a Gene Krupa legend. They were trying to — I call it "humping the grave." They just keep trying to hump the grave you know. So now like here is Anita O'Day playing at Michael's Pub in New York. And I had worked with her with the Buddy Rich band at the Blue Note. And they brought some drummer in from Boston, who, I don't know whatever happened, I don't even know who he was or what he was, but he lasted about one night and she was pretty rough to deal with. And so she remembered me and she said, "get that drummer that was with Buddy Rich's band." So I went in and worked with her at Michael's Pub for ten weeks, something like that. And then I went on the road with her. Went to Europe with her and went to Japan a couple of times with her, and recorded with her out at Vine Street with Pete Jolly and all those guys. But man, did she and I ever become drinking partners. Wooh. And she could drink. But one time man, see I used to have this thing what I call the "wet season" and a "dry season." From January 1st to July 4th, I would not even eat

rum cake. But then July 4th until January 2nd I would drink at least a quart of vodka a day. And that went on for years and years and years.

MR: How come?

DD: Well I drank to forget.

MR: But it must take a lot of self control to just like —

DD: You've got to say what do you want to forget?

MR: What do you want to forget? Okay.

DD: That I'm ashamed.

MR: Uh huh. Ashamed of?

DD: The fact that I drink. That was actually from "The Little Prince." When he went to see the tippler. He said, "why do you drink so much?" He says, I drink because I'm — whatever it was, "I drink to forget." "Forget what?" "Forget that I'm ashamed." "You're ashamed of what?" "That I drink." So it's a round robin. But one time, I'm not going to mention any names again but we had a piano player who was a pretty good drinker at the time. And he really needed to quit drinking. And he quit drinking. So I meet her — we arrive in, I think it was Torino, Italy, and he's not with the band. She hired somebody else. She didn't hire him for this tour because of the drinking. But it's not because he drank too much. So we're checking in the hotel. We came on different flights but for some reason we're checking in the hotel. So Anita — I called her Colton, because her real name was Anita Colton. So I always said Colton. So she goes, "Danny, as soon as I take my bags up I'll meet you in the bar." I said, "Colton, I'm not drinking." She looked at me and she says, "I fired a piano player because he quit drinking. I'll see you in the bar." I said, "okay, I'll be right down." I mean can you imagine getting fired off a gig because you quit drinking? I mean that was Colton man. She was just nuts man. And she had been a big junkie too you know. But my dry season ended right then and there.

MR: I see. You had to readjust your calendar.

DD: Yeah I had to readjust.

MR: Did you ever get fired from a gig because you were drinking?

DD: Naa.

MR: That's amazing.

DD: Nope.

MR: That you would get fired because you weren't drinking.

DD: Can you imagine getting fired because you quit drinking? Jeez. That was Colton.

MR: "If I'm doing it, you're doing it."

DD: Right. "I'll see you in the bar." I said, "I'll be right down." I didn't need to get sent home from wherever we were going.

MR: Uh huh. What was she like in the studio?

DD: I was never with her in the studio. I was with her in a live performance at the Vine Street Bar & Grill which was — a lot of recordings were done at Vine Street — Pete Jolly, Bob Mayes, Gordon Briscer was on it, a very nice man. He's since gone to his reward.

MR: Who was that you mentioned?

DD: Gordon Briscer, the saxophone player.

MR: Okay, suppose I have a grandson and he's a very good musician and he wants to be a jazz musician and he's debating about college, or he just wants to go to New York City and be a musician, and I asked you — what do you think about that? Do you think I should encourage that kid to do such a thing?

DD: Well along my lines were I wanted my — I had twin sons and I wanted one of them to be a piano player and the other one to be a drummer. Well the drummer became a very good drummer. I mean Grade 6 A solos in fifth or sixth grade. Then I had a set of vibes, because I figured if he's going to get into percussion he's got to learn all that. And then I had that bass in the corner. And one day he said, "what's that?" I said, "it's a string bass." And he said — and I gave him his first bass lesson. Well that was it for him. I mean bass was his instrument. Now, he just took to it. I mean, it's like me, piano, trumpet, drums, and then bass as a secondary instrument. He just loved it. And it hurt his hands. And his — my grandson — wanted to be like grandpa, play drums. That didn't — I got a houseful of drums and he had drums at home. That didn't work for him. Then he tried the bass, because of his father. That didn't work. Now he's got my father's trumpet and he loves it. I mean he's just playing in the band and everything else. But my son, who does play and makes a lot of money, I mean his pension's ridiculous, is a professional musician at the Kennedy Center. His bass never even leaves the building. Although he did go with the National Symphony over to China and Korea and all this and that, touring, whenever they tour. But you've got to let them find their own way, man. It's like you can't say — first of all, the thing that amazes me is that they have all of these universities and schools now. I never attended an institution of higher learning. As I said, I didn't go to Ithaca College so I never — but I gave seminars and clinics at colleges you know, when I was with those bands. They wanted to know what I knew, which I learned from the seat of my pants. But the thing is, the thing that I'm not getting is all of these schools have all of these things — all of this music that we didn't have available to use, it's all there now. I've got a whole big thing, stacks of music, which was not available when I was coming up. But a school teacher, he gets a job, he graduates from college, and I mean he might, if he's lucky (and even that's slowing down) get a cruise ship for a couple of months and get on one of those ships. But they're even cutting back. A drummer might, because half of the music is a drummer playing along with a keyboard player and a soundtrack. So I mean all of that's shutting down. The big bands are basically, I mean the Basie band, I mean how

much can they work. Woody Herman's band maybe works 15 weeks a year. There's no bands to go on anymore. So going to New York, I mean even the studio work — now Broadway, I don't know, because I never was into the Broadway — I worked at the Roseland Ballroom this and that. But I don't see — it's kind of like you go to college to learn how to be a teacher so you can teach somebody else how to be a teacher. But how do you get actually involved with what you're being taught, other than to be a teacher. So it's like there's no light through the tunnel.

MR: What's the scene?

DD: Yeah. What's the scene? I mean I go into Central Park now and I hear guys playing their asses off. But they've got their cases open for nickels and dimes and quarters and a couple of one dollar bills that they probably put in there themselves. So I don't recommend getting into the music business. I mean I caught the tail end of it with the guys that were still — I mean not Glenn Miller — but I was on Woody Herman's band and I was on Maynard Ferguson's band, I was with Anita O'Day and things like that. I was with Eddie Jefferson the night he was murdered. The singer. I was playing with him in Baker's Keyboard Lounge. The great vocalese. He was another hero of mine. And he had said that we're going to go into the Vanguard and this and that and everything was fine, Richie Cole and all this and that. And I walked out of the vestibule of the club on opening night at Baker's Keyboard Lounge. There was a Lincoln Continental out front. I got to town late. So thank God I got to town late, otherwise Eddie would have been driving with me, riding with me. And I checked into a different hotel around the corner. And I got in my car and drove around the corner, getting ready for a nice week with Eddie, and I turned on the television and it said, "jazz singer Eddie Jefferson was murdered last night in front of Baker's Keyboard Lounge." Well I called Richie Cole. So he said, "Danny, you missed it by 30 seconds." You know if I had got to town later — or earlier – I would have been standing right there. A shotgun took him down. So I just got in the car and drove straight home. I said let me get out of here. Detroit's not my town with this. But that was with Eddie Jefferson. I loved him. I loved working with him too. But no I can't recommend going into this business. I mean you're involved with it. I don't know. I mean there's so many guys out there it's just ridiculous, and girls now, and I don't know if the race thing is involved. I don't know. I'm not in the game anymore. I'm not in the competition. I don't need a gig anymore. I don't need money.

MR: Did you ever witness any racial incidents or that kind of thing in your career? I know as you said, your time in the business was supposedly a little after much of that was worked out.

DD: Yeah I had one. I auditioned with Horace Silver. He just died by the way. Randy Brecker was on the band, Bennie Maupin, I can't remember the bass player, and Horace. And so

they were holding auditions up at Lynn Oliver's studio. Mike Garson got me the audition. He was David Bowie's conductor for, I don't know, forever. And I went up there and I played first. And I was the only white guy auditioning on drums. Billy Cobham was leaving and a replacement was being held for him. I mean auditions were taking place. And one guy played, a black guy played. And he wasn't particularly good. He wasn't very good. But Horace was nice about it, and let him play a couple of tunes. Then called me up, and I played about four or five tunes with him. And then everybody's sitting over there. Then another black guy comes up to play drums. Better than the first, but not particularly good. Then he said, "Danny, why don't you come on up and play some more." So I played another three or four tunes with Horace Silver. So now Mike Garson is there and we're waiting to go down to Dave Liebman's loft to have a session, but we're waiting for Randy Brecker to come down. Now Bennie Maupin, the tenor player, who had been with Head Hunters during my first sitting down to play the drums, had walked to the other end of the studio and played against the wall. Wouldn't come up on the stand and play with me. But when Horace called me up the second time, he came up on the — it was a little raised platform at Lynn Oliver's studio, and did play with me. And Randy Brecker, now we're waiting for Randy downstairs, it's like a half an hour man. You know and we're going down to Liebman's. And he said, "Horace wants to hire you, man," but he says, "he knows if he puts a white drummer on this band," he said, "it's going to cost him about 40 percent of his work."

MR: Who said that to you?

DD: Randy Brecker.

MR: Randy. Okay.

DD: Because they had a band meeting up there. He said, "he wants to use you but he can't." So we went down and the next morning I'm staying at Mike Garson's and the phone rings and Mike says, "Danny, it's Horace Silver." And I said, "what?" I mean I must have got the gig, Horace Silver's calling me. And you don't forget it when you get a call from Horace Silver. He said, "Danny, it was obvious you were far superior to all those other drummers there. But there's one other guy I want to hear in Philadelphia." And that guy lasted about a week. But I felt a draft as you would say. Now I'm not saying that I would have lasted a week either, but at least I play better than the guys that were there.

MR: It's ironic because they told Benny Goodman the same thing — you're going to lose 40 percent of your work if you hire Lionel Hampton or whatever.

DD: Artie Shaw had that whole scene when he had Hot Lips Page and he couldn't even do a southern tour unless Hot Lips was at least like ten feet away from the rest of the band. He turned down a whole southern tour. And Billie Holiday was with that band too and there

were some problems along those lines too. But I mean other than that I can't say there's been an awful lot as far as I'm concerned with the black and white thing.

MR: Do you think if you could be born at a different time — did you ever feel like you were born a little too late?

DD: Since I'm now still alive, no. Because I would have been long gone.

MR: That's a great answer.

DD: But guys have told me that jeez if you were around in the 40's and like that, like you'd be — Stan Getz offered me a gig that night at Carnegie Hall, right after the gig. We went up to the party afterwards because we did this thing and he played with the band, and he said when you get off this band call me. I never did. But I understand that he was not the most fun guy to work with.

MR: Well I'm jealous of some of your playing experiences, because I often times think I was born a little too late. But we're both still here. And I'm going to remember that answer.

DD: Yeah because I'd be gone, long gone. But man I can't say that I have an awful lot of regrets in life. I mean my life ambition in high school was to someday play with Woody Herman's band and Maynard Ferguson's band. And I had achieved both of that when I was 27. So I mean I was offered Count Basie's band, when I was with Maynard's band, and I said — I was offered that twice I think and I turned it — I am kind of regretful that I turned it down. Although I do have a feeling that the intensity that I was playing and the style that I was playing and accustomed to playing with Maynard's band, I might not have been — it would have taken some adjusting to go with Basie's band, you know, because we were on top of everything. We were playing way on top of the beat and with Basie it was much more laid back. And probably Basie might have had to have a talk with me if I had taken the job.

MR: I find that fascinating, this idea of playing on top of the beat. How can you — I heard Louis Hayes one night at some club and I said, "he is so on top of this beat, how does this music not speed up?" Or maybe it does.

DD: Maybe it does. Well you see I don't know, because each guy's got a different cymbal beat. Like Jimmy Cobb, you would think he'd be playing quarter notes, but he's actually playing a real tight sixteenth note. But you see what I did, the way, my father, when he first showed me the beat, he said, "this is the way the beat goes," and he had to do it with two hands. But the way I practiced it was I would go [drums]. So if you play a flam [drums] then you're not playing it right as far as I'm concerned. So it's got to be [drums]. Rather than [drums]. Because the right stick is not where I hear the time. So it's like the swinging thing. So like I always play it that way and then some guys just play straight quarter notes [drums] you know like that. And then there's [drums]. And Cozy Cole almost played [drums]. I mean I never could quite figure that one out. But each guy's got

their own cymbal beat. Louis Hayes, and each guy works differently, works better with certain bass players. Like Louis Hayes and Sam Jones hit it beautifully, and also Philly Joe Jones and Paul Chambers hit it beautifully. But Louis Hayes and Paul Chambers didn't hit it as well, and Philly Joe didn't hit it quite as well with Sam Jones. So everybody's got their own time feel that works for them. Bass players, for me, I mean I'm very particular about bass players you know. And really, if I'm going to be able to be free — I know that if my arm starts to hurt I'm doing something — I'm trying to adjust to something. That's just me.

MR: And is it something you can actually tell a bass player.

DD: No. You can't. It's where he hears the time. The one thing that I do on most occasions — the thing that bothers me the most is okay you get to the gig and you see the bass player there and the hatchback's opening up and the first thing I see that comes out of the hatchback is the stool. I say that's a stand-up bass. Stand on your two feet and play it man, you know because you're anchored. For instance, like Miles Davis used to tell guys, you don't play like with the front part of your foot. I mean that's not anchored. You've got to stand up. When you see Paul Chambers or any of these guys play you see their heel like this [plays bass]. Not like [plays bass]. I mean you're off balance. It's got to be like — Miles had to tell the guys play it. It's your spine to the heel [plays bass]. You see?

MR: Okay.

DD: So when I see a guy sitting down, his feet aren't even on the floor, half the time they're up on the thing, what are you playing with? It's coming from your head to your fingers. It's supposed to come right straight through your body. For me.

MR: Okay. Well put. Well this is a great room to be in. And we're coming up on our two hour mark here. So this has been a real fascinating conversation.

DD: Any final questions that you want to ask me?

MR: Yeah. How do you define swing?

DD: Didn't Fats Waller or somebody say if you have to ask that question you'll never know or something like that.

MR: Ralph Sutton told me that Fats Waller said, "get that right ticking rhythm and it's happening" or something like that. I actually like the fact that certain things can't be defined.

DD: Yeah, well it's got to be felt. How do you define love? I don't ever tell — a lot of guys, I mean the more you say "I love you" the less it means. I mean ending every phone call to a grandchild or to your son — some people say it ad nauseum. You can't end your conversation with "I love you." It's like Edwin R. Murrow saying "good night and good luck." And I never say "I love you" to my sons. They don't need to know that. I don't need to remind them. I don't say it to my grandchildren. But I got a Father's Day card

from my granddaughter and in it she said, “Grandpa I will always love you.” That meant more to me than a thousand phone calls ending with “I love you.” The written word supersedes the spoken word anytime for me. And that’s just the way I see it. But I have a different philosophy in life. I don’t believe in — well I won’t go into that.

MR: You don’t believe in?

DD: Monogamy.

MR: I see.

DD: That’s just me. But I’ll tell you one thing in parting. What you’ve got about 30 seconds left? A tom-tom can’t be played by every Tom Tom Dick Dick Harry Harry [drums].

MR: All right. I can’t think of a better ending. It’s been a real pleasure.

DD: It’s been my pleasure.

MR: And you know what? I hope I get to play with you someday. Maybe I can keep up I’m not sure. All right. Well thanks a lot, Danny.

DD: You’re more than welcome and I’d like to get a copy of this sometime. I’m sure that it will be edited. There’s some things in there that probably would not particularly get your faculty excited, but you know what to do.

MR: Yeah. Okay. Thanks a lot.

DD: Okay man.